

## SMM Iron Ore Daily

2026-09-18 Friday · Imported &amp; Domestic Ore · Prices · Supply-Demand · Inventory · Commentary

Source [SMM Data-pro](#)

## Futures Contracts

Closing price

SGX Iron Ore Most-traded Contract [Daily](#)95.80 USD/dmt  
▲ +0.36 +0.38%  
MTD avg 98.20  
As of Sep 17 · vs Sep 16DCE Iron Ore Most-traded I2701 [Daily](#)715.5 yuan/mt  
▲ +5.0 +0.70%  
MTD avg 722.2

## SMM Iron Ore Price Index

All five MMi as of Sep 18 · vs Sep 17

MMi 61% Port Spot [Daily](#)689 yuan/wmt  
▲ +4 +0.58%  
MTD avg 697MMi 58% Port Spot [Daily](#)647 yuan/wmt  
▲ +1 +0.15%  
MTD avg 650MMi 65% Port Spot [Daily](#)843 yuan/wmt  
▲ +5 +0.60%  
MTD avg 839MMi 61% Seaborne Index [Daily](#)97.15 USD/dmt  
▲ +0.45 +0.47%  
MTD avg 97.17MMi 65% Seaborne Index [Daily](#)113.40 USD/dmt  
▼ -0.55 -0.48%  
MTD avg 115.40SMM Domestic Ore Composite Index [Daily](#)837.61 yuan/mt  
▼ -8.33 -0.98%  
MTD avg 841.26

## Key View

## Restocking landed and mill stocks jumped 4.37 million mt in a week — but ports turned back to building, and SMM says the restocking is near its end

There is one central fact this period: **pre-holiday restocking has genuinely arrived, and at scale**. Imported ore stocks at 242 mills rose 4.37 million mt in a week to 78.61 million (+5.89%), with days of consumption rebuilt from 19.3 to 20.5 — ending the two-week pattern of mills running lean and refusing to restock. Prices responded: Qingdao Port spot rose 5-11 yuan/wmt and the DCE contract gained 5.0 yuan to **715.5 yuan/mt**, up for a third straight session. Two qualifications matter. First, **SMM states plainly that “with restocking nearing its end, price support is weakening”**, and reports mills buying only essential volumes with spot trading thin — this is passive pre-holiday cover, not a demand expansion. Second, and more important: **ports have turned back to building**. The 35 ports ended their run of draws and rose 840,000 mt to 144.33 million, with outflows down to 3.21 million mt. SMM's outlook for next week is blunter still: the lagged effect of earlier shipments will lift arrivals while demand fails to improve and outflows stay weak, so **port stocks should build again with the pressure increasing**. In other words, mills built this cover precisely as ports began to accumulate. Two further threads are worth noting. SMM's analysis concludes this decline was **driven from outside China** — the SGX contract fell 2.43% on the week, twice the DCE's 1.05%, while Chinese futures and spot fell almost identically, leaving the domestic pricing chain running smoothly; and the **Fed's first rate hike in three years** landed, within expectations but still a drag on upside. Today's indices reinforce it: all four domestic readings rose (the 65% port spot index +0.60% to 843, the 61% +0.58% to 689) while the **65% seaborne index fell 0.48% to USD 113.40/dmt**; the high-low spread widened another 4 yuan to 196 yuan/wmt, a fifth straight session and 13 yuan up from 183 on Sep 14. On balance prices should **keep trading in a narrow range with a soft centre**, in line with SMM's view. Once the restocking support fades, port accumulation and the failure of hot metal to recover will drive pricing again.

## Today's Highlights

◆ **Pre-holiday restocking landed: mill stocks jumped 4.37 million mt in a week**. Imported ore stocks at 242 mills rose from 74.24 to **78.61 million mt** (+4.37 million mt WoW, +5.89%), with days of consumption rebuilt from 19.3 to **20.5 days** (+1.2). This is the direct confirmation of SMM's call a day earlier that some mills had begun restocking — and the scale exceeded expectations.

◆ **But SMM says the restocking is near its end**. Prices followed higher across the board — Qingdao Port spot rose 5-11 yuan/wmt (PB fines 678, Carajas fines 845, SSF 540, Newman lump 878) and the DCE most-traded I2701 settled at **715.5 yuan/mt** (+5.0 yuan, +0.70%), up for a third straight session. Yet SMM reports **mills buying only essential volumes and spot trading thin**, and warns explicitly that “with restocking nearing its end, price support is weakening”.

◆ **Ports have turned back to building, with outflows weakening**. Inventory at the 35 ports rose from 143.49 to **144.33 million mt** (+840,000 mt, +0.59%), ending the run of draws, while daily outbound volume fell to 3.21 million mt (-25,000 mt). SMM expects **arrivals to keep rising next week and outflows to stay weak, so port stocks should build again with the pressure increasing**.

◆ **This decline was driven from outside China**. SMM's analysis notes a sharp split this week: the SGX most-traded contract fell from 98.19 to USD 95.80/dmt (-2.43% on the week), **twice the DCE's -1.05%**, while Chinese futures and spot fell almost identically (both around 1%), showing the domestic pricing chain running smoothly. Also note the **Fed's first rate hike in three years** — within expectations, but still a drag on any upside. The same split showed up in today's indices: the 65% port spot index rose 0.60% to 843 while the **65% seaborne index fell 0.48% to USD 113.40/dmt**.

## Qingdao Port Imported Ore Spot Prices

yuan/wet mt · tax incl. · 2026-09-17 → 2026-09-18

| Product                                                      | 09-18 (yuan/wmt) | Daily change / % | MTD avg | Last 12 months |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|------------------|---------|----------------|
| <b>PB Fines</b> 60.8% <a href="#">Daily</a>                  | <b>678</b>       | ▲ +5 +0.74%      | 688     |                |
| <b>Newman Fines</b> 61.2% <a href="#">Daily</a>              | <b>683</b>       | ▲ +5 +0.74%      | 695     |                |
| <b>Mac Fines</b> 60.8% <a href="#">Daily</a>                 | <b>681</b>       | ▲ +5 +0.74%      | 692     |                |
| <b>BRBF</b> 62.5% <a href="#">Daily</a>                      | <b>735</b>       | ▲ +2 +0.27%      | 745     |                |
| <b>Newman Lump</b> 63% <a href="#">Daily</a>                 | <b>878</b>       | ▲ +5 +0.57%      | 888     |                |
| <b>Super Special Fines (SSF)</b> 56.5% <a href="#">Daily</a> | <b>540</b>       | ▲ +5 +0.93%      | 550     |                |
| <b>Carajas Fines (IOCJ)</b> 65% <a href="#">Daily</a>        | <b>845</b>       | ▲ +5 +0.60%      | 844     |                |
| <b>PB Lump</b> 61.5% <a href="#">Daily</a>                   | <b>873</b>       | ▲ +5 +0.58%      | 884     |                |

## Imported Ore USD Prices &amp; MMi Indices

CFR Qingdao · USD/dry mt

USD prices 2026-09-17 → 2026-09-18

| Product                                                    | 09-18 (USD/dmt) | Daily change / % | MTD avg | Last 12 months |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|------------------|---------|----------------|
| <b>Carajas Fines (IOCJ)</b> 65% <a href="#">Daily</a>      | <b>116.25</b>   | ▲ +0.67 +0.58%   | 115.84  |                |
| <b>PB Lump</b> 61.6% <a href="#">Daily</a>                 | <b>120.24</b>   | ▲ +0.68 +0.57%   | 121.65  |                |
| <b>BRBF</b> 62.5% <a href="#">Daily</a>                    | <b>100.58</b>   | ▲ +0.23 +0.23%   | 101.76  |                |
| <b>Newman Fines</b> 61.2% <a href="#">Daily</a>            | <b>93.17</b>    | ▲ +0.65 +0.70%   | 94.67   |                |
| <b>Mac Fines</b> 61% <a href="#">Daily</a>                 | <b>92.88</b>    | ▲ +0.65 +0.70%   | 94.22   |                |
| <b>Jimblebar Fines</b> 60.5% <a href="#">Daily</a>         | <b>91.03</b>    | ▲ +0.79 +0.88%   | 90.76   |                |
| <b>FMG Blend Fines</b> 58.5% <a href="#">Daily</a>         | <b>88.61</b>    | ▲ +1.50 +1.72%   | 88.30   |                |
| <b>Newman Lump</b> 63% <a href="#">Daily</a>               | <b>120.95</b>   | ▲ +0.68 +0.57%   | 122.12  |                |
| <b>Super Special Fines (SSF)</b> 57% <a href="#">Daily</a> | <b>72.80</b>    | ▲ +0.64 +0.89%   | 74.11   |                |
| <b>Indian Fines</b> 57% <a href="#">Daily</a>              | <b>69.66</b>    | ▲ +0.63 +0.91%   | 69.86   |                |

SMM Iron Ore Price Index weekly / monthly statistics

| Index                                                                     | Month-to-date avg | MoM           | YTD           | Unit     | Last 12 months |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|---------------|---------------|----------|----------------|
| <b>SMM MMi 61% Iron Ore Seaborne Index</b> <a href="#">Daily</a>          | <b>97.17</b>      | <b>+1.93%</b> | <b>-8.3%</b>  | USD/dmt  |                |
| <b>SMM MMi 65% Iron Ore Seaborne Index</b> <a href="#">Daily</a>          | <b>115.40</b>     | <b>-0.33%</b> | <b>-6.6%</b>  | USD/dmt  |                |
| <b>SMM MMi 61% Iron Ore Port Spot Index</b> <a href="#">Daily</a>         | <b>697</b>        | <b>+1.03%</b> | <b>-15.3%</b> | yuan/wmt |                |
| <b>SMM MMi 65% Iron Ore Port Spot Index</b> <a href="#">Daily</a>         | <b>839</b>        | <b>+0.73%</b> | <b>-6.2%</b>  | yuan/wmt |                |
| <b>SMM MMi 58% Iron Ore Port Spot Index</b> <a href="#">Daily</a>         | <b>650</b>        | <b>+1.68%</b> | <b>-9.9%</b>  | yuan/wmt |                |
| <b>SMM China Domestic Ore Composite Price Index</b> <a href="#">Daily</a> | <b>841.26</b>     | <b>+0.03%</b> | <b>-5.5%</b>  | yuan/mt  |                |

All four domestic indices rose while offshore high grade fell alone: the 65% port spot index added 5 yuan to 843 (+0.60%), the 61% 4 yuan to 689 (+0.58%) and the 58% 1 yuan to 647; the 61% seaborne index gained USD 0.45 to 97.15, but the **65% seaborne index fell USD 0.55 to 113.40 (-0.48%)**, moving opposite to its domestic counterpart — precisely how this week's “offshore falls alone” pattern shows up in high grade. The high-low spread widened another 4 yuan to 196 yuan/wmt, a fifth consecutive session of widening and 13 yuan up from 183 on Sep 14.

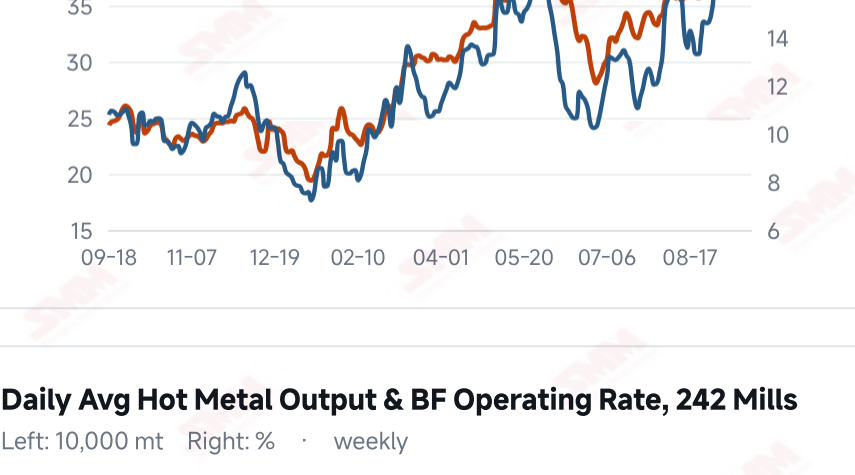
\* SMM quotations for Newman Fines and PB Lump (both CNY and USD) start in Mar 2026; their sparklines cover that shorter window only. All others show the past year.

## Key Price Drivers

Last 12 months

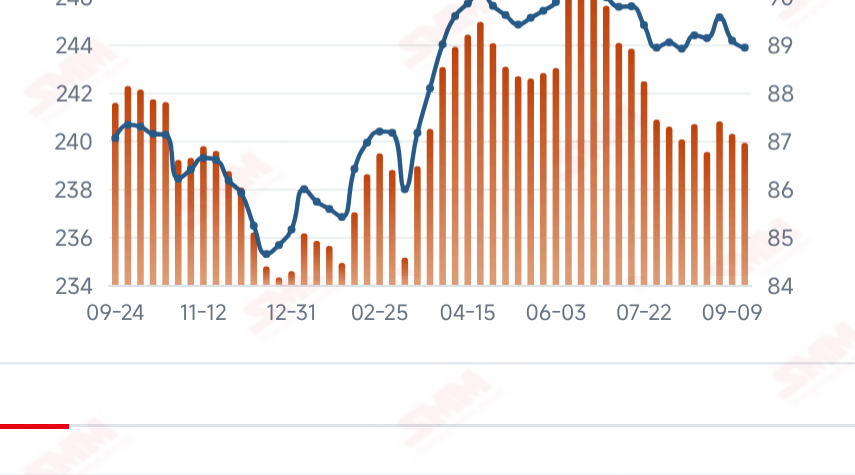
## Iron Ore Ocean Freight

USD/mt · daily · last 12M · C3 Tubarao→Beilun/Baoshan, C5 W. Australia Dampier→Qingdao/Beilun/Baoshan



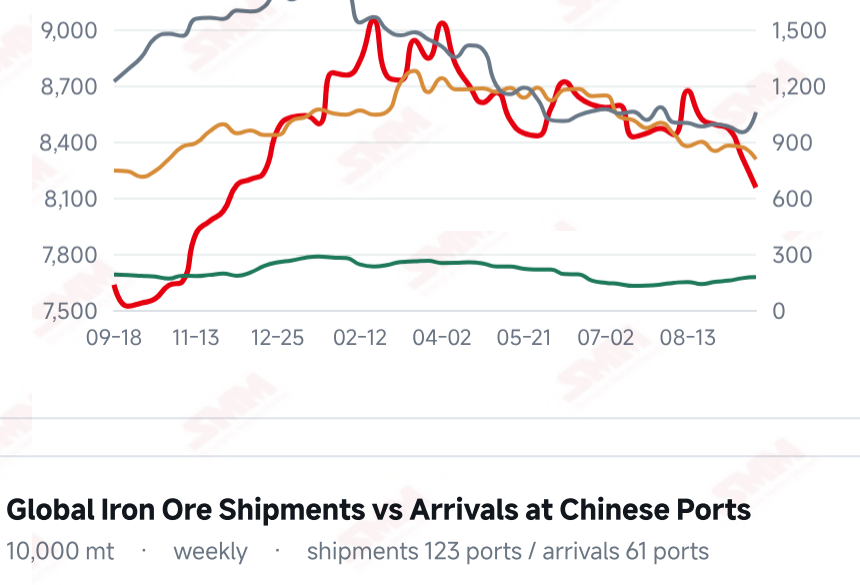
## Daily Avg Hot Metal Output &amp; BF Operating Rate, 242 Mills

Left: 10,000 mt Right: % · weekly



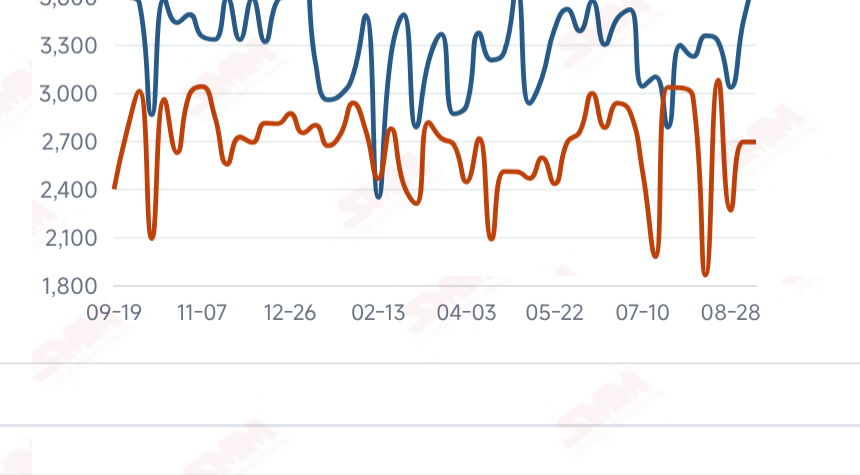
## Iron Ore Port Inventory at 10 Ports · by Product

Left: Fines Right: concentrates / lump / pellets · 10,000 mt · weekly



## Global Iron Ore Shipments vs Arrivals at Chinese Ports

10,000 mt · weekly · shipments 123 ports / arrivals 61 ports



## Market Commentary · Imported Ore

## Futures &amp; Spot

Prices followed higher across the board. The DCE most-traded I2701 settled at 715.5 yuan/mt, up 5.0 yuan (+0.70%) from Sep 17 and higher for a third straight session, though SMM describes the day as “firm in the morning, easing in the afternoon”; the SGX most-traded contract was at USD 95.80/dmt (as of Sep 17, +0.38%). On SMM's basis Qingdao Port spot rose 5-11 yuan/wmt: PB fines 678, Newman fines 683, Mac fines 681, Newman lump 878, SSF 540, Carajas fines 845 and PB lump 873 yuan/wmt, with BRBF up 2 yuan to 735. SMM notes, however, that **traders quoted reasonably actively but mills bought only essential volumes and spot trading was thin** — the rally rests on little actual business.

## Driver

The week traced a dip then a recovery: I2701 fell from 718 yuan/mt last Friday to a weekly low of 707.5 on Sep 15 before rising back, ending about 1.0% lower on the week. SMM lists the drags as: near-universal losses at long-process mills after the fifth round of coke increases, with maintenance and shutdowns widening; persistent rumours around long-term contract talks, raising fears of low-grade port stocks being released and more mid-grade tonnage becoming tradeable; the rebound in 35-port inventory; and the **Fed's first rate hike in three years** souring sentiment. The single support was larger pre-holiday restocking — which SMM judges to be **close to running its course**.

## Demand

**Restocking has landed, but it is essential buying rather than expansion**. Imported ore stocks at 242 mills rose from 74.24 to 78.61 million mt (+4.37 million mt WoW, +5.89%) and days of consumption were rebuilt from 19.3 to 20.5 days (+1.2), ending the sustained lean-inventory pattern. Output has not improved, though: as of Sep 16 the blast furnace operating rate across 242 mills was 88.93% (-0.15 ppt) and daily average hot metal 2.3991 million mt (-3,700 mt), with no new print this period. SMM stresses that **end-use demand remains weak, mill profitability is deteriorating and pig iron output has yet to recover, leaving iron ore without an upward driver**, and sees no clear turning point in end-use demand.

## Inventory &amp; Supply

**The port picture has turned**. Inventory at the 35 ports rose from 143.49 to 144.33 million mt (+840,000 mt, +0.59%), ending the run of draws, while daily outbound volume fell to 3.21 million mt (-25,000 mt, -0.77%). SMM's read: arrivals were broadly stable this week, but deepening mill losses pulled hot metal down and outflows turned to a build. **Looking to next week, SMM expects the lagged effect of earlier shipments to lift arrivals further while demand fails to improve and outflows stay weak, so port stocks should build again with the pressure increasing**. The 10-port total was 101.9125 million mt (as of Sep 17, -1.1059 million mt WoW), with lump building 1.0688 million mt against the trend. Global shipments last week were 37.4058 million mt (+8.59%) and arrivals at Chinese ports 26.9105 million mt (steady).

## Cost &amp; Margin

The average imported ore loss narrowed from 3.97 to **2.87 yuan/mt**, which SMM attributes to lower C5 freight and correspondingly cheaper landed costs for Australian cargo. The two routes keep diverging: C5 Australia→China fell another USD 0.29 to 16.08/mt (-1.77%), extending its slide from 17.77 on Sep 14, while C3 Brazil→China recovered USD 0.59 to 42.56/mt (+1.41%, both as of Sep 17). SMM expects import margins to stay in modest loss.

## Market Commentary · Domestic Ore

## Prices

**The domestic composite index finally updated, and fell sharply**. The SMM China Domestic Ore Composite Price Index reads **837.61 yuan/mt** as of Sep 18, down 8.33 yuan (-0.98%) from Sep 17, catching up in one move with the past fortnight's regional pullback — Shandong 64% alkaline concentrate down to 816 yuan/mt and Tangshan 66% concentrate to 935-940 yuan/mt delivered, dry basis and tax inclusive.

## Supply &amp; Demand

Supply stays tight: concentrator run rates remain low, state-owned operations largely consume their own output and private concentrate supply is short. On demand, deepening mill losses keep buyers pressing hard on domestic concentrate prices; pre-holiday restocking notwithstanding, purchasing remains essential-only and cannot offset the downward pressure on prices.

## Outlook

Domestic ore's earlier counter-trend strength has fully faded. With mill losses deepening and imported ore restocking near its end, domestic concentrate should stay soft near term; further strength in imported high grade would offer only limited relative-value support.

## Market Factors

## ▲ Supportive factors

- Imported ore stocks at 242 mills jumped 4.37 million mt to 78.61 million, rebuilding cover to 20.5 days.
- Qingdao Port spot rose 5-11 yuan/wmt and the DCE contract gained 5.0 yuan to 715.5, up a third session.
- The average imported ore loss narrowed from 3.97 to 2.87 yuan/mt.
- C3 Brazil→China freight recovered 1.41% to USD 42.56/mt, still supporting Brazilian grades.
- Chinese futures and spot fell almost identically, with SMM noting the domestic pricing chain running smoothly.
- The high-low spread widened 4 yuan to 196 yuan/wmt, a fifth straight session and 13 yuan in total; high grade stays firm.

## ▼ Bearish factors

- SMM states plainly that with restocking nearing its end, price support is weakening.
- The 35 ports turned to a build, +840,000 mt to 144.33 million, with outflows down to 3.21 million mt.
- SMM expects arrivals up and outflows weak next week, increasing the port build pressure.
- Mills bought only essential volumes and spot trading was thin; the rally lacks transacted support.
- Pig iron output has yet to recover, with hot metal at 2.3991 million mt and the operating rate at 88.93%.
- The Fed's first rate hike in three years landed, capping upside across commodities.

## Flash News

Last 2 days · click to open

- [SMM Brief] With restocking nearing its end, price support for iron ore is weakening
- Ports turn back to building as outflows weaken; no demand turning point, ore stays soft [SMM Daily Iron Ore Review]
- Iron Ore Port Inventory and Outbound Volume, Sep 18, 2026 (35 ports 144.33 million mt, +840,000 mt WoW)
- SMM Imported Iron Ore Cost & Margin Table, Sep 18, 2026 (average loss 3.97→2.87 yuan/mt)
- [SMM Imported Ore Analysis] Supply pressure surfaces, offshore falls alone, ports return to building
- Ocean Freight and Dry Bulk Shipping Indices, Sep 17